

ing to accept Azhagiri and his "party for me, the government (chief minister's post) for you" formula. A few years ago, Azhagiri was offered a "specially created" post of south zone organisational secretary. He was given the charge of managing eight southern districts where all district secretaries from the constituencies falling under the districts were asked to report to Azhagiri. Among these district secretaries, many were traditionally Stalin supporters.



**KARUNANIDHI WITH
DAUGHTER AND RAJYA
SABHA MP KANIMOZHI**

While Azhagiri enjoys full support of three district secretaries, the remaining five, though Stalin supporters, were unable to disobey him. Now, Azhagiri is pressuring his father to hand over the control of three more districts to him. These districts are DMK strongholds and by taking charge of these areas, Azhagiri plans to have a firm grip over many of the MLAs and MPs in the state and strengthen his support base. Stalin, of course, will have none of this.

Tamil Nadu has seen 10 by-elections during the current DMK regime. In all these elections, both Stalin

and Azhagiri worked hard to prove themselves as vote catchers. Yet, many say in all the by-elections, it was Azhagiri who saw to it that all the electoral logistics (freebies and money) were handed over to the voters and ensured the party's stellar victories. The media too called him the "by-election specialist". But, in a recent party working committee meet, one of the resolutions praised Stalin's way of handling political issues in Delhi. Azhagiri expected that the resolution regarding by-election victories will give due credit to him. When he found that the resolution appreciated "all those who had worked hard for the victory", Azhagiri went away without attending the afternoon session. During the same session, Azhagiri supporters had placed posters in the name of Azhagiri Peravai. Karunanidhi immediately ordered the removal of all such

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posters and announced that the party has issued an order to ban the efforts to form a new association in the name of "Azhagiri Peravai" and will take stern action against anyone who disobeys.

The distance between the brothers manifests often at crucial junctures. Even in the recent Pennagaram by-election, the so called "by-election specialist" Azhagiri did not participate in the campaign. Instead, he chose to visit Australia in his capacity as Union minister. But Karunanidhi, who didn't campaign for the previous by-elections, is campaigning at Pennagaram this time. Many see this as Azhagiri's way of communicating his dissatisfaction.

With the power struggle between the brothers approaching its peak, Karunanidhi is said to be reconsidering his June retirement. Speaking at a function, he said that his health isn't as bad as what a lot of people make it out to be. This is perhaps the first indication that he may now opt to wait rather than make way for Stalin, as promised earlier. Since there is no anti-incumbency feeling in the state and with the Opposition in disarray, he may even be toying with the idea of preponing the assembly polls, due next year. Sources in the DMK say the party leadership is waiting for the Pennagaram by-elections to be over and will then decide its future course of action. Till then Karunanidhi himself might continue to be the chief minister. He may be projected as the chief ministerial candidate even for the next assembly polls though, if the DMK wins a majority, Stalin may take over as chief minister.

Karunanidhi realises that the Stalin Vs Azhagiri power tussle is getting out of hand, but in the spat between the two, the younger is his favourite and any tiff between the two may not bode well for his party's future in the state. Over the years, Karunanidhi has managed to weaken the base of its staunchest enemy, the AIADMK, and in the last Parliament elections, he foxily snapped his ties with his constant critic S. Ramadoss' Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) and made it bite the dust. He also made Vijayakanth's Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), politically insignificant, lose its deposit in the by-elections.

Though the party doesn't have a clear majority in the state Assembly, Karunanidhi rules the state with the outside support of the Congress. Right now, neither Jayalalithaa nor Ramadoss are his worst enemies but it is the simmering cold war between his two sons that is Kalaigarnar's biggest worry. The future of the DMK will depend a lot on how this 85-year-old veteran of many a political battle will tackle the enemy within. ■